

Tai Chi for Arthritis Joint Pain: Proven Benefits

Practical NHS-backed advice on tai chi for arthritis joint pain benefits.

By **Living With Arthritis UK** · Reviewed by **Louis Maxwell** (HCPC Registered Physiotherapist) · 2026-07-24 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

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Quick Answer: Tai chi is strongly recommended for arthritis by NICE guidelines. Regular practice reduces joint pain and stiffness, improves balance, and reduces fall risk — particularly in knee osteoarthritis and rheumatoid arthritis. Even 20 minutes twice a week produces measurable benefits within 8–12 weeks.

Tai chi is a gentle, flowing form of exercise uniquely well-suited to people with arthritis. Unlike high-impact activities, it protects joints while building strength, flexibility, and balance.

What the Evidence Says

Multiple clinical trials confirm tai chi's benefits for arthritis. A 2016 Cochrane review found tai chi significantly reduced pain and improved physical function in knee osteoarthritis. Arthritis Research UK and NICE both include tai chi as a recommended self-management strategy.

Specific Benefits

- Reduces joint pain scores in OA and RA
- Decreases morning stiffness duration
- Improves range of movement in affected joints
- Reduces fall risk by up to 45% in older adults
- Strengthens muscles around affected joints

- Improves proprioception and balance
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How to Get Started



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Look for a class specifically designed for people with arthritis or older adults. The Arthritis Foundation Tai Chi programme is an evidence-based 8-week course available at many UK leisure centres. Tell the instructor about your arthritis — most movements can be adapted. Start with 10–15 minutes and build gradually.

Q&A;

Question: Is tai chi safe if my arthritis is severe? **Short answer:** Generally yes, but check with your physiotherapist first. Chair-based tai chi is available for those with significant mobility

limitations.

Question: How often should I practice for arthritis benefits? **Short answer:** Twice weekly for at least 8 weeks produces significant benefits according to clinical trials. More frequent practice accelerates improvement.

Question: Where can I find free tai chi classes for arthritis in the UK? **Short answer:** Many leisure centres offer free sessions through Exercise on Referral schemes (ask your GP). Age UK and local arthritis groups also run free tai chi classes.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk